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booths with over 15 per cent voter growth in four years. Kannauj's rolls, it says, have 291,798 questionable entries, among them voters recorded as over 100 years old. In Kolathur, the BJP claims 19,476 suspect voters, including repeated names under multiple voter IDs in the same booths.

But the cut and thrust continued. Former Union minister and BJP MP Anurag Thakur even claimed that Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, who was born in Italy, was added to the voter list in 1980, three years before she became an Indian citizen. Even within the Congress, uncomfortable questions emerged. Karnataka cooperation minister K.N. Rajanna acknowledged that the irregularities Rahul highlighted had occurred while the Congress was in power in the state. He said it was a lapse, an issue the party should have pressed before, not after, the polls. Not surprisingly, he lost his job soon afterwards.

THE ECI STONEWALLING

All this while, the ECI has adopted an air of bureaucratic hauteur. Instead of countering Rahul's allegations with data, it insisted he file a formal, signed declaration—which would turn a political charge into a potential legal liability. Former chief election commissioner O.P. Rawat says such a demand is unnecessary, noting that the provision under Rule 20(3)(b) of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, requiring claims and objections to be submitted on oath, applies only during an electoral roll revision. Since Rahul's charge was based on a political party's research, Rawat says, the rule doesn't apply, and the ECI should have begun a probe into his allegations immediately. Rahul refused to comply, and ECI officials insinuated he was unwilling to stand by his claims. The standoff culminated in high political theatre on August 11, when nearly 300 Opposition lawmakers marched from Parliament toward the ECI's offices.

Ironically, several BJP leaders claimed Rahul's exposé had done the ECI a favour. His criticisms of faulty rolls, they argued, were a tacit endorsement of the poll body's ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Bihar. The exercise, they said, was precisely about cleaning the rolls of bogus voters. Announced on June 24, 2025, the SIR is an unprecedented